

November 15, 2024
Kentucky Waterfowl Ground Counts

This is the ground count survey for November 11 - November 15, 2024. The region experienced varied, mild weather throughout the week, with rainfall of up to 2 inches in some areas due to showers and thunderstorms early in the week. Western Kentucky remains in a state of moderate drought. Although recent rainfall helped improve conditions slightly, long-term deficits persist from dry summer months. The Ohio and Mississippi Rivers' levels have generally remained stable but are slightly below normal.

The first day of Special Youth Waterfowl Season is Saturday November 23, 2024. The first day of Special Veteran's Waterfowl Season is Sunday, November 24, 2024. The first segment of duck season will open on November 28, 2024 and run until December 1, 2024. Goose season will open on November 28, 2024 and run until February 15, 2024. All bag limits will remain the same as the previous season. Check out the [2024-2025 Waterfowl hunting guide](#) or visit the waterfowl hunting web page for more details. Good luck hunting this year. Be safe and enjoy your time afield.

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Location	Number	Species Composition	Comments
Ballard 11/14/2024	9710 total ducks 250 divers 9460 dabblers 4 Canada geese	89% mallard, 7% gadwall, 2.5% ring-necked, 1% green-winged teal, <1% wigeon and pintail,	Rain yesterday and front pushing through today, turning cooler. Waterfowl numbers have been increasing with this weather front coming through. Just got a river to be able to pump this past week, so just starting to flood hunt units. Moist soil units look good and had an excellent corn crop this year as we flood our units.
Boatwright 11/14/2024	263 ducks 5 Canada geese 3 eagles	67% mallard, 33% unknown ducks	Cold front overnight, 1.5in rain day before. Picking up birds daily.

Duck Island <i>Not surveyed</i>			
Doug Travis WMA <i>Not surveyed</i>			
Sloughs WMA <i>Not surveyed</i>			
Peabody WMA <i>Not surveyed</i>			
Yellowbank WMA <i>11/14/2024</i>	65 ducks	90% mallard, 10% wood duck	Most units are at 50% water capacity. Excellent moist-soil plants and row crops in hunting units.
Barren River WMA <i>Not surveyed</i>			
Blue Grass Army Depot (all lakes and ponds) <i>Not surveyed</i>			
Cave Run Lake <i>Not surveyed</i>			

November 22, 2024
Kentucky Waterfowl Ground Counts

This is the ground count survey for November 18 - November 22, 2024. The region experienced light rainfall early in the week, with amounts generally below 0.5 inches. Most areas stayed dry towards the weekend, with temperatures ranging from cold to moderate. Western Kentucky has mostly recovered from the recent drought conditions thanks to rainfall earlier in November. The Ohio and Mississippi Rivers' levels have generally remained stable but are slightly below normal.

The first day of Special Youth Waterfowl Season is Saturday November 23, 2024. The first day of Special Veteran's Waterfowl Season is Sunday, November 24, 2024. The first segment of duck season will open on November 28, 2024 and run until December 1, 2024. Goose season will open on November 28, 2024 and run until February 15, 2024. All bag limits will remain the same as the previous season. Check out the [2024-2025 Waterfowl hunting guide](#) or visit the waterfowl hunting web page for more details. Good luck hunting this year. Be safe and enjoy your time afield.

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Location	Number	Species Composition	Comments
Ballard <i>Not surveyed</i>			
Boatwright <i>Not surveyed</i>			
Duck Island <i>Not surveyed</i>			
Doug Travis WMA <i>11/20/2024</i>	200 ducks	Mix of mallards, wood ducks, gadwall, and hooded mergansers	The Beaver Pond Rest Area is at 95% water capacity and holding most of the ducks we saw today. Impoundment 3-1 (Upper Lake Erie) in Indian Camp Rest Area is 90% full,

			with an excellent stand of mixed moist soil vegetation. With Baldy's Woods nearing water capacity, we plan to divert some of the water pumped by the #3 well back to impoundments 3-1 and 3-2. There is huntable water in Baldy's Woods walk-in unit, and at blind sites 11, 12, 16, 17, and 18, as well as in all of the WMA lakes featuring blind sites. Well #1 is pumping to raise water levels in the Willow Slough Rest Area, and into the standing corn at Blinds 16 and 17. We are slow in accumulating water in the blinds 13/14 impoundment due to low river and groundwater levels, as well as a malfunctioning valve in the pipeline to Blind 13. We have been increasing water flow from the #2 Well to the outlet at Blind 14 with the goal of raising water levels in this impoundment. There is no water in the Ward Tract walk-in unit at this time.
Sloughs WMA 11/19/2024	1125 ducks 172 Canada geese 450 WF geese 40 snow geese	80% mallard; 10% teal; 5% pintail; 4% miscellaneous dabblers – northern shoveler, gadwall, American widgeon observed; 1% miscellaneous divers	Lots of water on the area at this time compared to last season. Most ducks observed were in the marsh and tucked into thick areas, likely causing an under representation of total numbers. There is a wide range of habitat quality across the area; natural vegetation is overall great, some

			planted crop struggled due to mid-summer drought.
Peabody WMA <i>Not surveyed</i>	11 ducks 172 Canada geese	100% mallard	Most lakes, moist soil units, and other water bodies are close to normal levels due to recent rainfall.
Yellowbank WMA <i>11/20/2024</i>	340 ducks	80% mallard, 10% wood duck, 10% green-winged teal	Most units are at 60% water capacity. Excellent moist-soil plants and row crops in hunting units.
Barren River WMA <i>11/18/2024</i>	25 ducks 150 Canada geese	50% divers (ruddy ducks, scaup), 50% dabblers (mallards)	Geese on pond, few ducks in small groups on main lake and next to bank with woody cover, no waterfowl on MSUs. Peters Creek MSU 40% full, Long Creek- Calvert Springs main unit 90% and units above and below the main spring 0-20%, MSUs off hwy 100 are 0-20% full, with corn/soybeans and MSU plants in great condition, tenant farmer still doesn't have beans out. Dry conditions, mature Bald Eagle in tree at CS main MSU probably eating left overs of a field dressed deer, dozens of fishing boats on the lake, loons and grebes present.
Blue Grass Army Depot (all lakes and ponds) <i>11/19/2024</i>	241 ducks 17 Canada geese	55% coots 19% mallards 15% black ducks 8% gadwall 2% wood ducks 1% ring-necked	Early in the season with usual suspects present, expect numbers and individuals to increase in the future.
Cave Run Lake <i>Not surveyed</i>			

November 29, 2024
Kentucky Waterfowl Ground Counts

This is the ground count survey for November 25 - November 29, 2024. The region experienced light to moderate rainfall, with some areas also receiving freezing precipitation earlier in the week. The week started with below-average temperatures, with daytime highs mostly in the 40s and nighttime lows in the 20s, leading to several nights of freezing conditions. Parts of western Kentucky remain in dry to moderate drought conditions, though some areas have improved compared to earlier in the fall. The Ohio River remains slightly below average for this time of year, while the Mississippi is near seasonal norms due to upstream rainfall.

The first segment of duck season will open on Thursday November 28, 2024 and run until Sunday December 1, 2024. Goose season will open on Thursday November 28, 2024 and run until Saturday February 15, 2025. All bag limits will remain the same as the previous season. Check out the [2024-2025 Waterfowl hunting guide](#) or visit the waterfowl hunting web page for more details. Good luck hunting this year. Be safe and enjoy your time afield.

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Location	Number	Species Composition	Comments
Ballard <i>11/27/2024</i>	16,758 ducks 73 Canada geese 2000 white-fronted geese	87% mallard 5% ring-necked 4% gadwall 4% misc ducks	Rain expected this afternoon and tonight as front approaches, then turning colder through Thanksgiving. The cold front that came through last week brought more waterfowl to the WMA. No change in habitat since last count. We are working to get big river pump back online, but wells are running to flood what hunt units we can.
Boatwright <i>11/27/2024</i>	763 ducks	69% mallards 31% unknown duck	3 eagles. Recent cold front.

Duck Island			
<i>Not surveyed</i>			
Doug Travis WMA			
<i>Date</i>			
Sloughs WMA <i>11/25/2024</i>	3127 ducks 117 Canada geese 1397 WF geese 800 snow geese 46 swan	80% mallard, 10% teal, 5% pintail, 3% gadwall, 6% misc dabblers – shoveler, wood duck, widgeon; 1% misc divers	Lots of water on the area at this time compared to last season. Most ducks observed were in the marsh and tucked into thick areas, likely causing an under representation of total numbers. There is a wide range of habitat quality across the area; natural vegetation is overall great, some planted crop struggled due to mid-summer drought.
Peabody WMA			
<i>Not surveyed</i>			
Yellowbank WMA <i>11/26/2024</i>	415 ducks	70% mallard 10% wood duck 10% GW teal 10% gadwall	Most units are at 60% water capacity. Excellent moist-soil plants and row crops in hunting units. Pumps are running into hunting units.
Barren River WMA			
<i>Date</i>			
Blue Grass Army Depot (all lakes and ponds) <i>11/26/2024</i>	280 ducks 21 Canada geese	50% coots 16% black duck 15% mallards 12% gadwall 4% wood ducks 3% ring-necked ducks	Cold fronts projected in the future, expect numbers of species and individuals to increase.

Cave Run Lake	94 ducks	93% bufflehead	
	83 Canada geese	4% mallard	
11/26/2024	8 pied-billed grebe	3% ruddy duck	

December 6, 2024
Kentucky Waterfowl Ground Counts

This is the ground count survey for December 2-6, 2024. The region experienced fluctuating weather, with highs in the upper 50s early in the week and lows around 20°F by midweek. Light precipitation, including rain and occasional snow showers, occurred Monday and Tuesday, but snow accumulation was minimal. Freezing conditions became widespread later in the week, with lows dipping into the low 20s and highs in the 30s to low 40s. Drought conditions have improved, and water levels on the Ohio and Mississippi Rivers have stabilized following earlier fluctuations.

The second segment of duck season will open on December 7 and run until January 31, 2025. Goose season will open on November 28, 2024 and run until February 15, 2025. All bag limits will remain the same as the previous season. Check out the [2024-2025 Waterfowl hunting guide](#) or visit the waterfowl hunting web page for more details. Good luck hunting this year. Be safe and enjoy your time afield.

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Location	Number	Species Composition	Comments
Ballard 12/5/2024	13,533 ducks 1,800 WF geese 6,400 snow geese	45% ring-necked duck 32% mallard 23% unknown duck <1% gadwall, wigeon, shoveler, pintail	Bitter cold front on the previous night – very windy. Waterfowl are looking for cover to get out of this high wind right now.
Boatwright 12/5/2024	226 ducks 5 eagles	73% mallard 27% unknown duck	Strong cold front pushing in. Low water in some areas.
Duck Island 12/4/2024	4,200 ducks 75 Canada geese 40 WF geese	45% mallard 15% pintail 15% GW teal 12% gadwall 10% ring-necked 3% shoveler <1% black ducks, canvasback, ruddy ducks	Current water level is ideal. Habitat conditions are fair/good.
Doug Travis WMA	1,500 ducks	85% mallard 15% mixed dabblers	We experienced a breakdown of well #3 on November 26 and are awaiting diagnosis from contractor. We are currently unable to pump water into

12/2/2024			Indian Camp Rest Area or Baldy's Woods Walk-in Unit with this well down. Wells #1 and 2 are running, and there is huntable water at blind sites 11-14 and 16-17.
Sloughs WMA 12/3/2024	9,995 ducks 42 Canada geese 2,730 WF geese 8,190 snow geese 128 swan	80% mallard 3% gadwall 6% pintail 5% teal 6% misc dabbler <1% misc diver	Significant portions of the area are freezing up but most hunt units with wells have some water being held open as well as the refuge
Peabody WMA 12/3/2024	184 ducks 52 Canada geese	44% mallard 30% gadwall 24% ring-necked 2% pintail & GW teal	Water levels are good in most wetlands and shallow water impoundments. Very shallow water has been freezing over the last couple of days due to low temperatures.
Yellowbank WMA 12/4/2024	760 ducks	80% mallard 5% wood duck 5% gadwall 5% pintail 5% black duck	Most MSU's are at 50% water capacity. Units without pumps are starting to lose water due to the lack of precipitation. Units protected from wind have sheet ice.
Barren River WMA 12/2/2024	355 ducks 150 geese	90% divers – bufflehead, ring-necked, ruddy, scaup 10% dabblers - mallards	Lake at 529.1. Peters Creek MSU 40% full. Long Creek - Calvert Springs main unit 90% and units above and below the main spring 0-20%. MSUs off Hwy 100 are 0-20% full, with corn/soybeans and MSU plants in great condition. Tenant farmer got beans out this past weekend. Dry conditions. 2 mature Bald Eagle fighting over Mason Island territory. 50 white pelicans on Goose Island point. Loons, mergansers, grebes present. Started putting water on Units above and below Calvert Springs today. Geese/ducks on pond, ducks in moderate sized rafts throughout the lake and tributaries, no waterfowl on MSUs.
Blue Grass Army Depot (all lakes and ponds)	405 ducks 20 Canada geese	50% ring-necked duck 16% mallard 16% black ducks 7% hooded merganser 6% gadwall	Recent cold fronts with north winds have brought a lot of waterfowl in compared to past weeks. Expect numbers to climb as more cold

12/2/2024		2% ruddy duck ≤1% pied-billed grebes, shovelers, and buffleheads	weather is anticipated in the coming days.
Cave Run Lake 12/4/2024	119 ducks 143 Canada geese 30 unknown	50% hooded merganser 27% bufflehead 10% coot 6% lesser scaup 5% pied-billed grebe <1% common goldeneye, common loon	Most of the smaller wetlands are iced over but could be easily broken. The lake and Licking River have open water.

December 13, 2024
Kentucky Waterfowl Ground Counts

This is the ground count survey for December 9-13, 2024. The region experienced typical early winter conditions this week, receiving light precipitation and snowfall with minimal snow accumulation. Overnight temperatures frequently dipped below freezing, leading to ice formation on some water bodies, pushing waterfowl into more open waters. Kentucky has largely recovered from summer drought conditions, and water levels on major rivers are normal or slightly below normal for this time of year.

The second segment of duck season opened on December 7 and will run until January 31, 2025. Goose season opened on November 28, 2024 and will run until February 15, 2025. All bag limits will remain the same as the previous season. Check out the [2024-2025 Waterfowl hunting guide](#) or visit the waterfowl hunting web page for more details. Good luck hunting this year. Be safe and enjoy your time afield.

[Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza was recently confirmed](#) in samples from several dead snow geese at Sloughs WMA (December 11, 2024), and dead geese have also been observed at Ballard WMA. Hunters should use common sense when handling/cleaning harvested waterfowl. See page two of the Waterfowl Guide for recommendations for the safe handling and disposal of your birds. After cleaning waterfowl, hunters are encouraged to place the remains in trash bags and dispose of them through trash collection or a permitted landfill. Bald eagles and other raptors are particularly susceptible to avian influenza. This simple action could help prevent bald eagle and other raptor mortalities. Please let WMA staff know if you observe any sick or dead birds.

Location	Number	Species Composition (listed most to least)	Comments
Ballard 12/10/2024	15,467 ducks 36 Canada geese 700 WF geese	34% mallard 30% ring-necked 23% gadwall 5% wigeon 4% shoveler 4% pintail < 1% wood duck, unknown dabbling	Weather has warmed, coming off from a freezing event. Ducks do not have a strong need to feed right now. Minimal hunting activity since season just began. Low water conditions on most of area. <i>Note: several snow geese were observed dead in impoundments that geese usually sit in. Please let staff know if you observe any sick or dead birds.</i>
Boatwright 12/11/2024	5,610 ducks 2 Canada geese	89% ring-necked 10% mallard 1% unknown duck	Minor fluctuations in temps recently but nothing abnormal. No noteworthy waterfowl activity since last week.
Duck Island <i>Not surveyed</i>			
Doug Travis WMA <i>Not Surveyed</i>			

Sloughs WMA 12/9/2024	9,251 ducks 30 Canada geese 5,050 Snow geese 176 swans	85% mallard 7% misc dabbling 5% northern pintail 2% gadwall 1% teal < 1% misc diver	Habitat conditions across the area are the same as previous weeks. Duncan 3 and 4 hunt units are now pumped for the first time in at least 4 years due to new well being functional. <i>Note: highly pathogenic avian influenza was confirmed to have killed several snow geese at the WMA over the course of the last week. Please let staff know if you observe any sick or dead birds.</i>
Peabody WMA 12/12/2024	194 ducks 183 Canada geese	48% mallard 32% ring-necked 10% gadwall 10% misc – GW teal, pintail, wigeon	Conditions at Peabody are fair. Water levels are a little below average for this time of year. Hunting pressure remains steady and most of the waterfowl observed were on large bodies of water and sheltered shallow water that was not frozen. Expected rain over the weekend into the first part of next week should help to improve conditions.
Yellowbank WMA 12/10/2024	940 ducks	70% mallard 10% wood duck 5% gadwall 5% black duck 5% northern pintail 5% ring-necked	Most units are at 75% water capacity. Excellent moist-soil plants and row crops in hunting units. Pumps are running into hunting units.
Barren River WMA 12/11/2024	105 ducks 150 Canada geese	90% diver – bufflehead, ring-necked, goldeneye, merganser 10% dabbling – mallard, wood duck	Peters Creek MSU 70% full, Long Creek-Calvert Springs main unit 90% full, units above and below the main spring 30-70% full. MSUs off Hwy 100 are 0-20% full with corn/soybeans and MSU plants in great condition. Dry conditions. 50 white pelicans at Narrows campground point; loons, mergansers, and grebes present. Few fishermen. Geese/ducks on pond, ducks in small sized rafts throughout the lake and tributaries. Dabblers on MSUs.
Blue Grass Army Depot (all lakes and ponds) 12/9/2024	260 ducks 15 Canada geese	26% black ducks 24% ring-necked 19% coots 15% mallards 4% buffleheads 4% ruddy ducks 4% canvasback 2% shovelers < 1% pied-billed	Recent cold fronts have pushed birds down but warmer days have caused a lot of birds to move around locally. Expect numbers to fluctuate in the coming days.

		grebes, merganser, gadwall	
Cave Run Lake <i>Not surveyed</i>			

December 20, 2024
Kentucky Waterfowl Ground Counts

This is the ground count survey for December 16-20, 2024.

The second segment of duck season opened on December 7 and will run until January 31, 2025. Goose season opened on November 28, 2024 and will run until February 15, 2025. All bag limits will remain the same as the previous season. Check out the [2024-2025 Waterfowl hunting guide](#) or visit the waterfowl hunting web page for more details. Good luck hunting this year. Be safe and enjoy your time afield.

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Location	Number	Species Composition	Comments
Ballard 12/17/2024	14,937 ducks 2,100 WF geese 30 Canada geese 8,700 snow geese	60% mallard 22% ring-necked 7% gadwall 6% wigeon 5% pintail ≤ 1% GW teal, shoveler, pintail, wood duck, black duck	Hunter success and water levels have been steady. Heavy rains in the region filled many impoundments and sloughs during this last couple of rain events. Migration reports still have many ducks north of our area.
Boatwright 12/18/2024	6,826 ducks	59% ring-necked 30% unknown 11% mallard	Lots of sheet water and flooded fields from recent rains and heavy precipitation should help with waterfowl activity in the area.
Duck Island Not surveyed			
Doug Travis WMA 12/16/2024	2000-4000 ducks – see notes		Levees were too soft after rain on 12/16 to conduct a full survey. From what was visible with limited access, there are 2000-4000 ducks utilizing the Beaver Pond Rest Area, mostly mallards with a small percentage of mixed dabbling ducks making up the remainder. There is sufficient water to

			hunt at all blind sites, and we continue to pump at blinds 16/17 and 11-14. We are continuing to work on getting well #3 repaired.
Sloughs WMA <i>Not surveyed</i>			No count this week due to levees being too wet from recent rainfall. As of 12/18, WF and snow goose numbers seem to be similar to last week. Ducks are likely spread out across the landscape with a good amount of sheet water present. Current river forecasts indicate the potential loss of access to portions of Highland Creek/Grassy Pond units next week if any more rain occurs.
Peabody WMA <i>12/18/2024</i>	95 ducks 164 Canada geese	77% mallard 23% gadwall, GW teal	Heavy rains have raised water levels and spread ducks and geese out over a larger area on the WMA.
Yellowbank WMA <i>12/16/2024</i>	825 ducks	80% mallard 10% wood duck 5% gadwall 5% black duck	Most MSUs are at 90% water capacity. 1.5 inches of rain in the last 12 hours started filling several field units that were dry.
Barren River WMA <i>12/19/2024</i>	165 ducks 180 Canada geese	90% dabblers – wood duck, widgeon, mallard 10% divers – bufflehead, ring-necked duck, goldeneye, merganser	Normal conditions. 50 white pelicans at Masons Island. Loons, mergansers, and grebes present. Several fishermen.
Blue Grass Army Depot (all lakes and ponds) <i>12/16/2024</i>	286 ducks 40 Canada geese 7 WF geese	28% ring-necked 23% black duck 17% coots 16% mallard 8% pintail 5% gadwall 2% shoveler 1% grebe	Fluctuating temps have pushed birds in and out over the past weeks, expect trend to continue until more sustained weather occurs.
Cave Run Lake <i>Not surveyed</i>			

December 27, 2024
Kentucky Waterfowl Ground Counts

This is the ground count survey for December 23-27, 2024. Due to the holiday season, many sites were not surveyed this week. We hope everyone had a great holiday.

The second segment of duck season opened on December 7 and will run until January 31, 2025. Goose season opened on November 28, 2024 and will run until February 15, 2025. All bag limits will remain the same as the previous season. Check out the [2024-2025 Waterfowl hunting guide](#) or visit the waterfowl hunting web page for more details. Good luck hunting this year. Be safe and enjoy your time afield.

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Location	Number	Species Composition	Comments
Ballard 12/26/2024	19,830 ducks 5,850 WF geese 13 Canada geese 3,501 snow geese	77% mallard 19% ring-necked 1% gadwall, GW teal, shoveler ≤1% wigeon, canvasback, pintail, bufflehead, unknown	Normal water levels for this time of the year and warm rising temperatures may contribute to decreased feeding behavior and lower hunter success rates. Long term projections predict a strong cold front in early to mid-January.
Boatwright 12/26/2024	4,300 ducks	70% ring-necked 29% mallard ≤1% gadwall, pintail, canvasback	Daytime temps spiking to 50° and a slight warming trend this last week have waterfowl numbers stable. Hunting continues as we draw close the 3 rd week of regular season. Hunters focusing on natural forage base and sloughs are returning higher success rates.
Duck Island Not surveyed			
Doug Travis WMA			

12/16/2024			
Sloughs WMA 12/23/2024	6,246 ducks 50 Canada geese 5,030 WF geese 12,000 snow geese 150 swans	90% mallard 5% pintail 3% gadwall 1% teal 1% misc dabbling <1% misc diver	
Peabody WMA <i>Not surveyed</i>			
Yellowbank WMA 12/23/2024	755 ducks	85% mallard 10% gadwall 5% black duck	Most MSUs are at maximum water capacity.
Barren River WMA <i>Not Surveyed</i>			
Blue Grass Army Depot (all lakes and ponds) 12/26/2024	471 ducks 26 Canada geese	66% ring-necked 16% mallard 9% black duck 5% gadwall 3% pintail 1% hooded merganser	Fluctuating temps have pushed birds in and out over the past weeks, expect trend to continue until more sustained weather occurs.
Cave Run Lake <i>Not surveyed</i>			

January 3, 2025
Kentucky Waterfowl Ground Counts

This is the ground count survey for December 30-31, 2024 and January 1-3, 2025. The region experienced heavy rains early in the week, filling many impoundments and pushing water into hunt units. Unseasonably mild temperatures early in the week gave way to a cold front with gusty winds and below freezing temps at night, moving many ducks around. Due to the holiday season, many sites were not surveyed this week. We hope everyone had a great holiday.

The second segment of duck season opened on December 7, 2024 and will run until January 31, 2025. Goose season opened on November 28, 2024 and will run until February 15, 2025. All bag limits will remain the same as the previous season. Check out the [2024-2025 Waterfowl hunting guide](#) or visit the waterfowl hunting web page for more details. Good luck hunting this year. Be safe and enjoy your time afield.

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Location	Number	Species Composition	Comments
Ballard <i>1/2/2025</i>	23,833 ducks 8,500 WF geese 1,311 Canada geese 12,000 snow geese	70% mallard 25% ring-necked 2% gadwall 1% GW teal 1% wigeon <1% pintail, shoveler, canvasback, bufflehead, ruddy duck, goldeneye, redhead, unknown	Heavy rainfall in the area over the past week helped to refill impoundments and push new ducks into the area. Recent flooding helped to increase water levels in the hunt units and across the landscape.
Boatwright <i>1/2/2025</i>	3,940 ducks 5 Canada geese	51% ring-necked 46% mallard 1% gadwall 1% pintail 1% canvasback <1% unknown	Smaller pools with overhead cover throughout the survey area held higher percentages of mallards. Swan pond was primarily where most of the diver species were observed.
Duck Island <i>Not surveyed</i>			

Doug Travis WMA 1/2/2025	800-1,000 ducks	90% mallard 10% GW teal, wood duck, gadwall, ring-necked	The ducks present on DTWMA were almost entirely in the Beaver Pond Rest Area, with most concentrated in flooded buckbrush. Around 50 ducks were present on the upper end of Willow Slough. All blind sites have plenty of water to hunt following the last rainfall events. There is some water present in the Ward Tract walk-in unit, although the impoundments are not full. Wells #1 and 2 are running at capacity, flooding impoundments around blinds 11-14 and 16/17. We are hopeful that repairs to Well #3 will be completed within the next 1-2 weeks.
Sloughs WMA 12/30/2024	5,766 ducks 65 Canada geese 260 WF geese 150 snow geese 24 swans	94% mallard 3% teal 1% gadwall 1% pintail 1% misc dabbler <1% misc diver	All floodable units are at full pool. Ducks are holding tight to thermal cover during the day and there are still good amounts of sheet water present on the landscape.
Peabody WMA 1/2/2025	79 ducks 247 Canada geese	Mixed mallard, gadwall, and ring-necked.	Conditions have remained about the same and waterfowl numbers are lower than usual for this time of the year on Peabody.
Yellowbank WMA 1/3/2025	590 ducks	75% mallard 10% gadwall 5% pintail 5% wood duck 5% ring-necked duck	Most MSUs are at maximum water capacity.
Barren River WMA <i>Not Surveyed</i>			
Blue Grass Army Depot (all lakes and ponds) 12/30/2024	381 ducks 38 Canada geese	59% ring-necked 16% mallard 13% black duck 8% gadwall 1% GW teal <1% pintail, common merganser, hooded merganser	Warmer trend has caused waterfowl to move a lot. Expect the forecasted cold snap to improve conditions over the next week.
Cave Run Lake <i>Not surveyed</i>			

January 10, 2025
Kentucky Waterfowl Ground Counts

This is the ground count survey for January 6-10, 2025. Western and central Kentucky experienced significant winter weather this week, bringing heavy snow, sleet, and freezing rain. Ice accumulations ranged from 0.25 to 0.75 inches and as much as 11 inches of snow in some areas, with more snow yet to come over the weekend. The storms and subsequent sub-freezing temperatures led to significant ice coverage on shallow wetlands and impoundments, reducing available open water for waterfowl. On some larger impoundments ducks are maintaining areas of open water. Stay safe and warm out there, and be prepared for icy conditions!

The second segment of duck season opened on December 7, 2024 and will run until January 31, 2025. Goose season opened on November 28, 2024 and will run until February 15, 2025. All bag limits will remain the same as the previous season. Check out the [2024-2025 Waterfowl hunting guide](#) or visit the waterfowl hunting web page for more details. Good luck hunting this year. Be safe and enjoy your time afield.

[Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza was recently confirmed](#) in samples from several dead snow geese at Sloughs WMA (December 11, 2024), and dead geese have also been observed at Ballard WMA. Hunters should use common sense when handling/cleaning harvested waterfowl. See page two of the Waterfowl Guide for recommendations for the safe handling and disposal of your birds. After cleaning waterfowl, hunters are encouraged to place the remains in trash bags and dispose of them through trash collection or a permitted landfill. Bald eagles and other raptors are particularly susceptible to avian influenza. This simple action could help prevent bald eagle and other raptor mortalities. *Please let WMA staff know if you observe any sick or dead birds.*

Location	Number	Species Composition	Comments
Ballard <i>1/8/2025</i>	35,239 ducks 32 Canada geese 11,300 WF geese 21,000 snow geese	91% mallard 6% ring-necked 1% gadwall <1% wigeon, BW teal, shoveler, pintail, wood duck	Strong polar vortex front couple days ago brought freezing rain, snow, and cold temps. Picked up lots of waterfowl with the cold front. Most shallow water units are frozen, but deeper water in some of the lakes is still open.
Boatwright <i>1/8/2025</i>	23,958 ducks 15 Canada geese 1,425 WF geese 3,000 snow geese	78% mallard 21% unknown ducks 1% unknown dabblers	Arctic blast 3 days ago – still cold. Lots of incoming migrating waterfowl in area. Lots of ice – open water becoming limited.
Duck Island <i>Not surveyed</i>			
Doug Travis WMA <i>1/8/2025</i>	See notes		Many of the wetlands on the WMA are partially or fully iced over, with more icing occurring with below-freezing temps again today. Some of the WMA

			lakes do have open water as of 1/8, and we are holding open water at blind sites 11, 13, 14, and 17 by running wells. Boat ramps at Black Lake, Fish Lake, and Town Creek impoundment were either ice-free or had minimal skim ice at the ramp. There were a few (<20) gadwall and wood ducks utilizing open water between blinds 16 and 17. There was a major movement of WF geese and snow geese coming from the west as we conducted the survey. We observed several thousand mallards and WF geese go into the Beaver Pond Rest Area, so we speculate that birds are holding an open hole in the ice there. We decided against entering the Beaver Pond to avoid disturbing these birds, but estimate numbers to be over 1,000 mallards and at least 2,000 white fronts using the Beaver Pond. The contractor is planning to finalize repairs to Well #3 over the next 2 days, so we hope to be pumping water into the Indian Camp Rest Area and Baldy's Woods walk-in hunt unit by the weekend if there are no difficulties with the installation.
Sloughs WMA 1/8/2025	Ducks – see notes 8,000 WF geese 12,000 snow geese Canada geese present 6 swans	See notes	Wells had to be turned off 1/4/25 due to ice storm. As a result, much of the water on the area locked up. Geese and ducks have held pockets open and wells are back on as of 1/8. Ducks are holding tight in open pockets of water on the refuge and snow/WF geese are hitting standing corn fields hard right now. High water and downed trees are preventing road access to Jenny Hole especially from the north. Timber and Little Jenny boat access is feasible from the east but Fishtrap may be inaccessible without great effort. No count to keep disturbance off ducks that are holding pockets of water open. Wells back on as of 1/8.
Peabody WMA 1/9/2025	143 ducks 25 Canada geese	70% mallard 29% gadwall	

		1% ring-necked duck	
Yellowbank WMA <i>1/7/2025</i>	965 ducks	90% mallard 5% gadwall 5% black duck	All hunting units have thick ice. Well pump and ducks are keeping the refuge open.
Barren River WMA <i>1/8/2025</i>	155 ducks 198 Canada geese	70% diver – bufflehead, canvasback, ring-necked, goldeneye 30% dabbling – mallard, teal, gadwall, black duck	Lake 534.2 up 0.2ft. Received 0.1in of rain in the last 24hrs. Peters Creek MSU 90% full. Long Creek-Calvert Springs main unit 90% and units above and below the main spring 60-70%. MSUs off Hwy 100 are 50-100% full, with corn/soybeans and MSU plants in great condition. Normal conditions. Ponds are locking up today/tonight. Great hunting for next several days on the lake.
Blue Grass Army Depot (all lakes and ponds) <i>Not Surveyed</i>			
Cave Run Lake <i>Not surveyed</i>			

January 17, 2025
Kentucky Waterfowl Ground Counts

This is the ground count survey for January 13-17, 2025. The region experienced a significant drop in temperatures due to a polar vortex, resulting in temperatures significantly below average. Conditions were clear but frigid, with many smaller water bodies and shallow wetlands completely frozen over, reducing available open water for waterfowl. Larger bodies of water with moving currents, such as rivers and managed impoundments, have remained partially open and have attracted concentrations of waterfowl seeking open water and food sources. Be cautious of icy conditions both on water and on land.

The second segment of duck season opened on December 7, 2024 and will run until January 31, 2025. Goose season opened on November 28, 2024 and will run until February 15, 2025. All bag limits will remain the same as the previous season. Check out the [2024-2025 Waterfowl hunting guide](#) or visit the waterfowl hunting web page for more details. Good luck hunting this year. Be safe and enjoy your time afield.

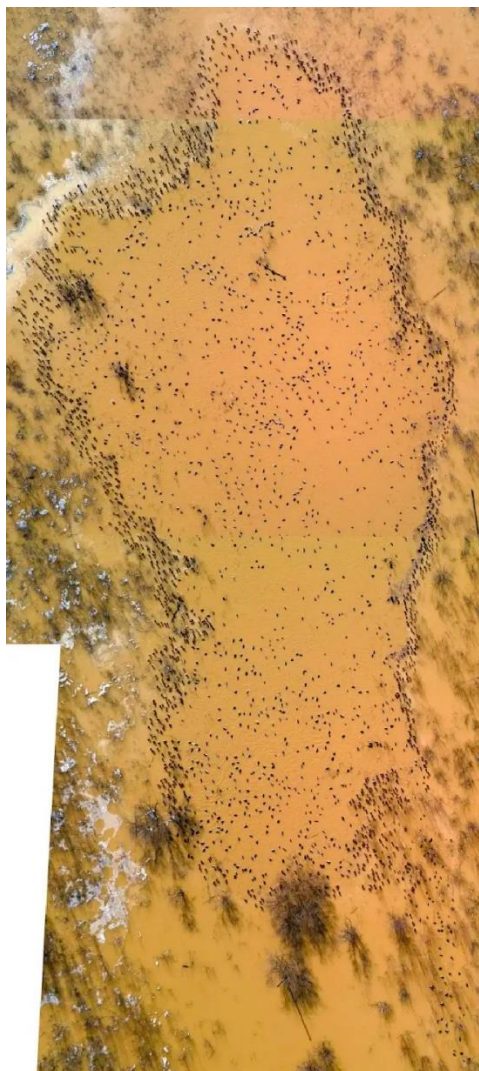
[Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza](#) was first confirmed in samples from several dead snow geese at Sloughs WMA in early December 2024, and has since been detected in 5 additional counties, with results in another 5 counties still pending. Hunters should use common sense when handling/cleaning harvested waterfowl. See page two of the Waterfowl Guide for recommendations for the safe handling and disposal of your birds. After cleaning waterfowl, hunters are encouraged to place the remains in trash bags and dispose of them through trash collection or a permitted landfill. Bald eagles and other raptors are particularly susceptible to avian influenza. This simple action could help prevent bald eagle and other raptor mortalities. *Please let WMA staff know if you observe any sick or dead birds.*

Location	Number	Species Composition	Comments
Ballard <i>1/15/2025</i>	40,635 ducks 9,100 WF geese 13,420 snow geese	93% mallard 3% gadwall 2% ring-necked 1% pintail 1% wigeon ≤ 1% shoveler, canvasback, GW teal, wood duck	Most shallow water units are still covered in ice. Large/deep bodies of water still remain open. Large numbers of snow geese present in area.
Boatwright <i>1/15/2025</i>	36,351 ducks 2,510 WF geese 36,400 snow geese 5 Canada geese	87% mallard 9% ring-necked 4% unknown	Vast majority of waterfowl was holding open water in loafing areas in refuge. Shallow pool areas remain frozen.
Duck Island <i>Not surveyed</i>			
Doug Travis WMA	2,000-2,5000 ducks	> 95% mallard < 5% misc	Most ducks are concentrated in Beaver Pond rest area, with a few scattered in

1/15/2025			the Twin Ponds/Willow Slough area. We saw a strong movement of snow and WF geese coming from the Missouri bootheel, but none were seen on the ground at DTWMA. All blind sites are at pool, although some are iced over. Well #3 is now repaired and pumping into the Baldy's Woods walk-in hunt unit and into "Upper Lake Erie" on the Indian Camp Rest Area. The field portion of Baldy's Woods now has huntable water, and Upper Lake Erie should be full by the end of this week and then will spill into the lower compartment behind Blind Site #6. Attached below is a photo of ducks in an "ice hole" in the Beaver Pond Rest Area during cold conditions, taken from a drone at 90 meters altitude.
Sloughs WMA 1/13/2025	10,930 ducks 18 Canada geese 4,000 WF geese 11,000 snow geese 130 swans	85% mallard 9% misc dabbler 5% gadwall 1% misc diver	Most hunting units with wells have open water. The timber unit within Jenny Hole is accessible but Fishtrap and Little Jenny boat ramps are frozen. Ducks seem to be roosting in hunt units overnight and returning to the refuge during daylight resulting in varied harvest success.
Peabody WMA 1/16/2025	502 ducks 272 Canada geese	47% ring-necked 26% mallard 15% gadwall 12% pintail, black duck, wigeon	Colder weather and temperatures have led to most shallow water areas being frozen. Most ducks and geese were observed on deep water lakes and feeding areas.
Yellowbank WMA 1/13/2025	655 ducks	90% mallard 5% gadwall 5% black duck	All hunting units have thick ice.
Barren River WMA 1/14/2025	230 ducks 30 Canada geese	70% divers – bufflehead, redhead, scaup, ring-necked, goldeneye 30% dabblers – mallard, teal, gadwall, black duck	The lake is at 531.5, down 0.6ft, and draining fast. Peters Creek MSU is 90% full. Long Creek- Calvert Springs main unit is at 90%, and units above and below the main spring are at 60-70%. MSUs off hwy 100 are 50-100% full, with corn/soybeans and MSU plants in great condition. Dry conditions, even large ponds are locked up with ice. Great hunting for next several days on the lake. Geese/ducks

			are on the lake, ducks are also in back of coves on the lake and tributaries, shady banks, and frozen MSUs.
Blue Grass Army Depot (all lakes and ponds) <i>1/13/2025</i>	200 ducks 156 Canada geese	37% ring-necked 23% mallard 20% gadwall 10% black duck 5% pintail 4% GW teal <1% common merganser, hooded merganser	Cold front has locked up all small bodies of water with the main lake remaining open in small pockets. Expect numbers to fluctuate with more freezing temps forecasted.
Cave Run Lake <i>Not surveyed</i>			

Figure 1. Ducks in an ice hole at DTWMA 1-15-25



January 24, 2025
Kentucky Waterfowl Ground Counts

This is the ground count survey for January 20-24, 2025. A strong arctic air mass settled over the region this week, leading to exceptionally cold conditions, with temperatures well below average and subzero nighttime lows with wind chill. The region remained mostly dry, with no significant precipitation or snowfall reported. The cold, dry air mass limited moisture availability, resulting in clear skies and frigid temps. Most smaller water bodies and shallow wetlands froze over, reducing available open water for waterfowl. Larger bodies of water with moving currents, spring-fed waters, and some waters exposed to the wind have remained partially open, particularly where waterfowl are concentrated and have helped keep ice holes open.

The second segment of duck season opened on December 7, 2024 and will run until January 31, 2025. Goose season opened on November 28, 2024 and will run until February 15, 2025. All bag limits will remain the same as the previous season. Check out the [2024-2025 Waterfowl hunting guide](#) or visit the waterfowl hunting web page for more details. Good luck hunting this year. Be safe and enjoy your time afield.

[Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza](#) was first confirmed in samples from several dead snow geese at Sloughs WMA in early December 2024, and has since been detected in 5 additional counties, with results in another 5 counties still pending. Hunters should use common sense when handling/cleaning harvested waterfowl. See page two of the Waterfowl Guide for recommendations for the safe handling and disposal of your birds. After cleaning waterfowl, hunters are encouraged to place the remains in trash bags and dispose of them through trash collection or a permitted landfill. Bald eagles and other raptors are particularly susceptible to avian influenza. This simple action could help prevent bald eagle and other raptor mortalities. *Please let WMA staff know if you observe any sick or dead birds.*

Location	Number	Species Composition	Comments
Ballard WMA <i>1/23/2025</i>	100,854 ducks 59,500 WF geese 96,500 snow geese	60% mallard 14% gadwall 10% ring-necked 7% pintail 4% wigeon 3% shoveler 2% GW teal ≤1% redhead, ruddy duck	Large flocks of snow geese and white fronts have helped to open large holes of water in refuge areas for duck use. There was several areas where the birds heavily congregated.
Boatwright WMA <i>1/22/2025</i>	30,023 ducks 150 snow geese	73% mallard 27% unknown	Arctic front has frozen most of the impoundments and water bodies in the area. The water continues to remain open from waterfowl usage on swan.
Duck Island <i>Not surveyed</i>			

Doug Travis WMA <i>Not Surveyed</i>			
Sloughs WMA <i>1/20/2025</i>	17,403 ducks 35 Canada geese 16,276 WF geese 20,844 snow geese 337 swans	95% mallard 2% teal 1% gadwall 1% pintail 1% misc dabbling <1% misc diver	Conditions remain the same across the area with the majority of water being frozen. Birds are hanging around in large concentrations on the refuge, mainly Pond Creek Marsh.
Peabody WMA <i>1/23/2025</i>	567 ducks 298 Canada geese	57% gadwall 31% mallard 10% ring-necked 2% canvasback, GW teal, pintail	Ducks and geese were observed on large deep lakes in unfrozen areas and shallow water areas with moving water. Most bodies of water on the WMA are frozen with very limited open water and available access.
Yellowbank WMA <i>1/22/2025</i>	24 ducks	100% mallard	All hunting units have thick ice.
Barren River WMA <i>1/21/2025</i>	1,545 ducks 290 Canada geese	50% divers – high diversity of all species – bufflehead, redhead, scaup, ring-necked, goldeneye 50% dabblers – mallard, teal, gadwall, black duck	Lake 528.2 down 0.3ft. Peters Creek MSU 90% full. Long Creek-Calvert Springs main unit at 90%. Units above and below the main spring at 60-70%. MSUs off Hwy 100 are 50-100% full, with corn/soybeans and MSU plants in great condition. Very dry conditions. Even large ponds are locked up and the lake is over half locked up in ice. Great hunting for next several days on lake. About 50 white pelicans on Mason's Island. Geese/ducks are on the lake and one pond. There are rafts of ducks all over the lake and flying around. Ducks huddled wing to wing in large groups on ice and tributaries. There are ducks at CS MSU.
Blue Grass Army Depot (all lakes and ponds) <i>1/22/2025</i>	379 ducks 178 Canada geese 1 trumpeter swan	34% mallards 17% black ducks 12% gadwall 11% ring-necked 6% GW teal 5% pintail 3% ruddy, bufflehead, redhead 2% common merganser, canvasback	Frigid temps have left all small bodies of water frozen, some pockets of open water remain on Lake Vega. Expect numbers to decrease as more water freezes on the lake.

		1% hooded merganser <1% grebes	
Cave Run Lake <i>Not surveyed</i>			

January 31, 2025
Kentucky Waterfowl Ground Counts

This is the ground count survey for January 27-31, 2025. The region experienced a warming trend, with highs in the mid-40s to mid-50s and lows in the upper 20s to mid-30s, leading to ice thawing in many areas. A significant rain event on January 30 brought over 2" of precipitation in some areas, increasing water levels in wetlands and expanding available waterfowl habitat. Waterfowl have continued to disperse with the warming temperatures. We apologize for the delay in updating last week's waterfowl counts and hunt data. The function to publish new reports on our web system was down.

The second segment of duck season opened on December 7, 2024 and will run until January 31, 2025. Goose season opened on November 28, 2024 and will run until February 15, 2025. The youth-only waterfowl hunt is on Saturday, February 8th and the military-only waterfowl hunt is on Sunday, February 9th. All bag limits will remain the same as the previous season. Check out the [2024-2025 Waterfowl hunting guide](#) or visit the waterfowl hunting web page for more details. Good luck hunting this year. Be safe and enjoy your time afield.

[Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza](#) was first confirmed in samples from several dead snow geese at Sloughs WMA in early December 2024, and has since been detected in 5 additional counties, with results in another 5 counties still pending. Hunters should use common sense when handling/cleaning harvested waterfowl. See page two of the Waterfowl Guide for recommendations for the safe handling and disposal of your birds. After cleaning waterfowl, hunters are encouraged to place the remains in trash bags and dispose of them through trash collection or a permitted landfill. Bald eagles and other raptors are particularly susceptible to avian influenza. This simple action could help prevent bald eagle and other raptor mortalities. *Please let WMA staff know if you observe any sick or dead birds.*

Location	Number	Species Composition	Comments
Ballard 1/30/2025	20,301 ducks 73 Canada geese 5039 WF geese 9580 snow geese	54% mallard 42% ring-necked 2% gadwall < 2% black duck, wigeon, teal, shoveler, pintail, canvasback, ruddy duck, hooded merganser, unknown duck	Warm up over the weekend and early week allowed a lot of iced-over areas to thaw, although there is still sheet ice in shallower waters and places not exposed to much sun/wind. Lots of waterfowl dispersed due to warmer weather. Big weather system with heavy rain moved in mid-week.
Boatwright 1/29/2025	12,570 ducks 17 Canada geese 95 WF geese 70 snow geese		Lots of birds dispersed with warming temps.
Duck Island			

<i>Not surveyed</i>			
Doug Travis WMA 1/29/2025	8,500 ducks	See notes	The warmer temperatures have resulted in portions of the DTWMA thawing over the last several days, with ducks responding to the “new water” provided. There were 6,000 ducks found using buckbrush/cypress habitat in the Beaver Pond Rest Area, with 90% of these being mallards, and the remaining 10% a mix of pintails, gadwalls, green winged teal, and wood ducks. With the repairs to Well #3 in Indian Camp Rest Area, we have achieved full pool in “Upper Lake Erie,” and “Lake Erie” is nearing full pool. These impoundments held 2,500 ducks, about an even mix of mallards and pintails. A steady trickle of ducks, mainly pintails, was arriving from the south and going into these pools as we surveyed. We are also pumping the Baldy’s Woods walk-in hunt unit with Well #3, and it is at capacity in the corn field, while the woods is still gaining water. We are at full pool around blinds 11-14 in Upper Goose Pond, and around blinds 16-17 in Twin Ponds. All lake blind sites have huntable water, although some ice is still present in shaded areas. We plan to keep the wells running through the youth/veterans’ weekend following the closure of regular duck season. Blind owner rights at the designated blind sites will still be in effect for the late weekend.
Sloughs WMA 1/27/2025	5,879 ducks 40 Canada geese 11,806 WF geese 7,662 snow geese 357 swans	90% mallard 5% teal 2% gadwall, misc dabbler 1% pintail <1% misc diver	Slow thawing has begun and should be accelerated with rains Thursday and Friday. Much of the area is still frozen over and evidenced by increased dry field feeding by all waterfowl.
Peabody WMA 1/29/2025	612 ducks 71 Canada geese	43% ring-necked 22% mallard 22% mix of redhead, black duck	All waterfowl observed were on deep lakes on areas that were not frozen. Geese that were using refuge areas have spread out over other areas as

		13% gadwall	warmer temperatures have made more open water and food available.
Yellowbank WMA <i>Not Surveyed</i>			
Barren River WMA <i>Not Surveyed</i>			
Blue Grass Army Depot (all lakes and ponds) 1/27/2025	229 ducks 2 Canada geese	51% mallard 35% black duck 6% gadwall 4% ruddy 4% greater scaup	Waterfowl have been restricted to moving water in creeks following the past negative temps, expect numbers to increase as more water continues to open up with the warmer forecasted temps.
Cave Run Lake <i>Not surveyed</i>			

February 7, 2025
Kentucky Waterfowl Ground Counts

This is the ground count survey for February 3-7, 2025. The region experienced mild temperatures throughout the week and rain on Thursday and Friday, with some locations receiving upwards of 1in of precipitation. Warmer temperatures have prompted many birds to disperse.

The second segment of duck season opened on December 7, 2024 and will run until January 31, 2025. Goose season opened on November 28, 2024 and will run until February 15, 2025. The youth-only waterfowl hunt is on Saturday, February 8th and the military-only waterfowl hunt is on Sunday, February 9th. All bag limits will remain the same as the previous season. Check out the [2024-2025 Waterfowl hunting guide](#) or visit the waterfowl hunting web page for more details. Good luck hunting this year. Be safe and enjoy your time afield.

[Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza](#) was first confirmed in samples from several dead snow geese at Sloughs WMA in early December 2024 and has quickly spread across the state. It has now been detected in 10 counties, with results in another 8 counties still pending. Hunters should use common sense when handling/cleaning harvested waterfowl. See page two of the Waterfowl Guide for recommendations for the safe handling and disposal of your birds. After cleaning waterfowl, hunters are encouraged to place the remains in trash bags and dispose of them through trash collection or a permitted landfill. Bald eagles and other raptors are particularly susceptible to avian influenza. This simple action could help prevent bald eagle and other raptor mortalities. *Please let WMA staff know if you observe any sick or dead birds.*

Location	Number	Species Composition	Comments
Ballard 2/5/2025	40,962 ducks 9,577 WF geese 62 Canada geese 11,000 snow geese	90% mallard 4% ring-necked 4% GW teal 2% gadwall, shoveler, goldeneye, canvasback, wood duck, pintail, wigeon, redhead, ruddy duck	Steady warming trend and rising river levels has led to birds dispersing across the landscape. Regular season has ended on Ballard WMA with exception of Youth/Veterans season.
Boatwright 2/5/2025	3,520 ducks	41% mallard 37% ring-necked 18% unknown diver 4% unknown	Dark goose season remains open on Boatwright WMA. Warming trend has ducks spread out.
Duck Island <i>Not surveyed</i>			
Doug Travis WMA			

<i>Not Surveyed</i>			
Sloughs WMA 2/4/2025	3,764 ducks 14 Canada geese 300 WF geese 100 snow geese 70 swans	90% mallard 5% teal 2% gadwall 2% misc dabbling 1% pintail 1% misc diver	Thawing out last week led to good overall hunting success. Lots of birds (both ducks and geese) observed migrating north on Friday. Most ducks are holding in thick cover making it difficult to get good estimates.
Peabody WMA <i>Not Surveyed</i>			
Yellowbank WMA <i>Not Surveyed</i>			
Barren River WMA <i>Not Surveyed</i>			
Blue Grass Army Depot (all lakes and ponds) 2/3/2025	507 ducks 9 Canada geese	41% ring-necked 20% coots 17% mallard 16% black duck 4% gadwall 1% shoveler 1% ruddy	Following the recent weather fronts pushing birds in and warmer weather, thawing ice has opened up all bodies of water.
Cave Run Lake <i>Not surveyed</i>			